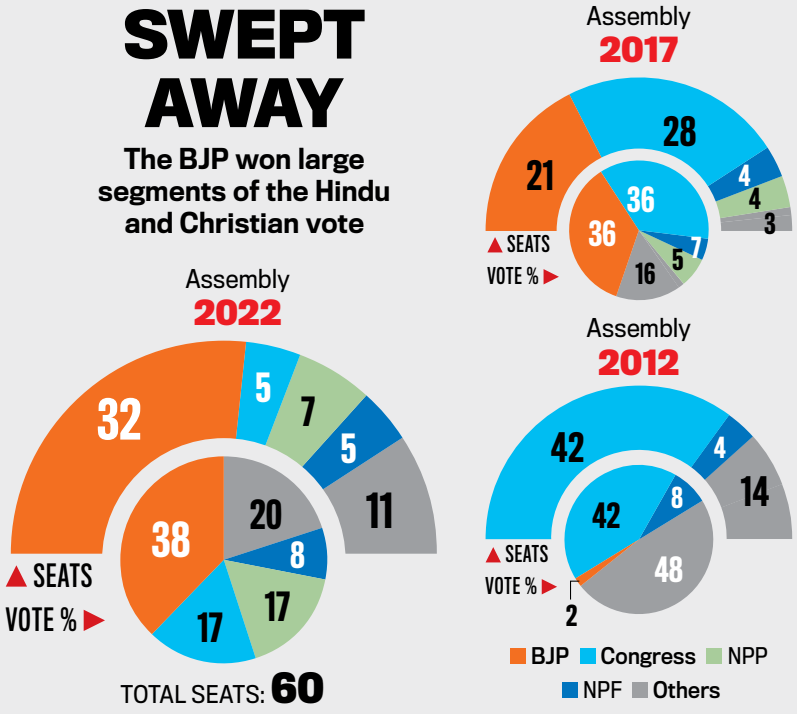
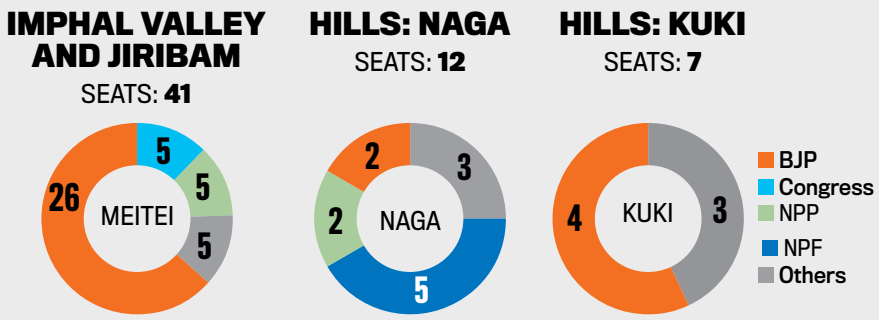
SWEPT AWAY

The BJP won large segments of the Hindu and Christian vote



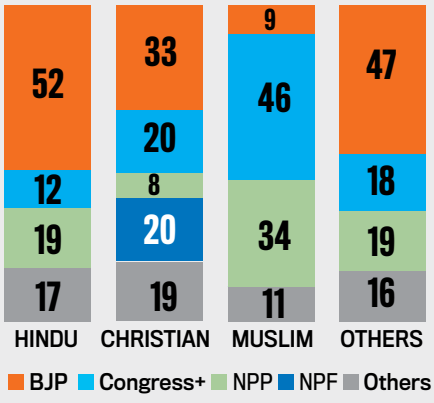
HOW MANIPUR VOTED IN 2022

GEOGRAPHIC BREAK-UP



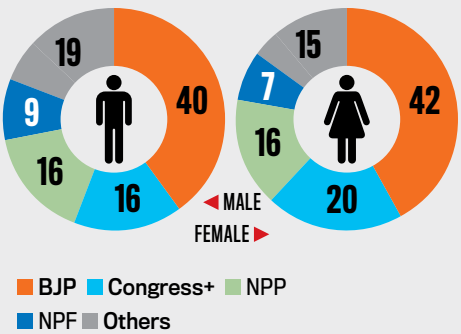
BREAK-UP OF VOTES

RELIGIOUS SPLIT



(Hindus and Christians make up 41 per cent each of the population; 8.4 per cent follow Islam and 7.8 per cent Sanamahism)

GENDER GAP



(Female voters: 1,057,336; Male voters: 990,627; Data for 2022)

Source: India Today-Axis My India Exit poll

were killed in terror-related incidents. In 2020, the figure was down to seven, with one civilian casualty. Though the figure spiked to 27 in 2021 (including seven civilians), this is something that often happens in pre-election years. "There is no doubt the past five years have been peaceful. And the BJP has benefited from this," says Professor Rajen Singh Laishram, head of the department of political science at Manipur University.

The BJP was also able to keep a lid on ethnic conflict. Of Manipur's 60 assembly constituencies, 40 are in valley areas, across six districts. The remaining 20 constituencies are spread over 10 districts. The valley districts, dominated by Meiteis, account for about 11 per cent of the state's area, but are home to 57.2 per cent of the population (about 1.6 million of the state's 2.8 million people, as per Census 2011). The remaining 42.8 per cent lives in the hill districts, which are dominated by Nagas and Kukis.

There is a long history of ethnic rivalry between these three communities. Economic blockades are frequently adopted as a form of protest and self-assertion. In fact, just before the 2017 poll, the state saw a four-month-long economic blockade called by the United Naga Council to protest the creation of seven new districts. In the past five years, the state has not seen a single economic blockade. "That shows the intent of our government. We have taken care of the demands of every community without hurting the interest of any," says Biren Singh.

Biren Singh also became the first chief minister in 15 years to be given a red-carpet welcome by local Naga communities in Ukhrul district, which has not only given the state two Naga chief ministers (Yangmaso Shazia and Rishang Keishing) but is also home to